

Green

Electronics Mammoth GE plans to spend \$10 billion in R&D for its green tech-initiative between now and 2015

Eagle Eye

Department of Homeland Security is developing camera surveillance which uses Image Stitching technology and can be used to monitor 360 degree view

SKOAR special



Obsidian Entertainment has created a fairly believable world of espionage with Alpha Protocol and in spite of some glaring flaws the game is an enjoyable experience

Ever since Obsidian Entertainment was formed out of the remnants of Black Isle Studio, the developers had to contend with working on sequels for games originally developed by Bioware. Alpha Protocol is the first opportunity these independent developers had with working on an entirely new game setting. The game gets its name from a fictional American covert programme that is typically tasked with undertaking operations for which the government does not want to be held accountable. The story is told through the exploits

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Genre: Action, RPG, Stealth

Studio: Obsidian Entertainment

Publishers: Sega

Platforms: PlayStation 3, PC (MS Windows), Xbox 360

Price: PlayStation 3, Xbox 360: Rs. 2,499/-, PC: 699/-

of a new recruit of the Alpha Protocol program, an agent named Michael Thorton.

Character creation

The choice of character type offers a fair bit of variety to encompass most typical playing styles. There is the stealth specialist who specializes in quite infiltration techniques coupled with a preference for pistols and unarmed combat.

After the player reaches a certain level, the game once again gives the option of choosing one of the three specialisations. At this point, one can reset the character development to pick an entirely different approach to the

game or continue on the initially selected class to max-out on certain skills.

Black-ops

Working for black-ops means that you are not always going to like what you have to do. Agent Thorton is assigned to track down a bunch of missiles that were allegedly stolen from American arms manufacturing company named Halbech and were used to destroy a passenger airliner. Just like every worthy story about the world of espionage, this story too has its fair share of twist and turns—it's about unexpected allies and betrayal when one least expects. Delving even slightly into the story would be entering spoiler territory, so all I will say here is that the game's plot is good enough to satisfy most RPG fans. Alpha Protocol is guilty of sticking to the unwritten law that most role-playing games have been following these days—that the plot has to be about saving the world. In spite of this, the story-telling is non-linear and it has a fair share of unexpected surprises. **d**



Most of the core issues from FIFA 10 remain unaddressed in this edition and it does not offer anything compelling to shell out the dough

The advent of the next FIFA World Cup inevitably brings a video game from FIFA license holders, Electronic Arts. The core game-play system—barring the penalty system—is pretty much unchanged from FIFA 10. The developers appear to have their hearts in the right place and ever since FIFA 08 there have been some commendable changes to a series that once appeared to be lost in doldrums. With each new

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Genre: Sports

Studio: EA Canada

Publishers: Electronic Arts

Platforms: PlayStation 3, PlayStation Portable, Xbox 360, PC, Nintendo Wii

Price: PlayStation 3, Xbox 360: Rs. 2,499/-, PlayStation Portable: Rs. 1,599/-, Nintendo Wii: Rs. 1,999/-

effort however, the final product appears to fall just short of the promise.

Line-up

As expected, FIFA World Cup South Africa features only the national squads and that makes it feel like a much smaller package when compared to the club-football editions. The good news is that this is somewhat compensated by a couple of additional game modes.

The only significant change with game-play is the new penalty system. While taking a penalty kick, the game now has two gauges—one for composure and another for kick power. The sizes of

safe zones on these gauges depend on the player's Penalty attribute. This is a fine attempt at adding psychological factors behind taking penalty kicks.

The new and the inherited

As mentioned earlier, there are several aesthetic improvements in World Cup South Africa over FIFA 10. EA has incorporated the World Cup's official colour scheme, which makes the interface appear a lot warmer as compared to the traditional FIFA interface that is largely black and white. Quick matches can now be started by pushing the two trigger buttons on the main menu and team selection can be made by navigating through a 3D-replica of the globe.

The only thing the World Cup editions of FIFA games have really going for them is the inclusion of national squads, and in our opinion they are kept out of the annual editions just for this reason. While being an official licensed game may seem like a good thing, it actually limits customisation options for the user. **d**